

PRELUDE

LEARNING & CONSULTANCY



PROPRIETARY METHODOLOGY

The Capability Readiness Playbook™

Training is rarely the problem. Capability is. A practical guide to diagnosing capability challenges in Defence and public sector organisations — before investing in training, consultancy or change.

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Why training isn't the problem

When performance slips, the reflex is to assume people need training. Sometimes they do. Far more often the knowledge and skill are already present, and performance is held back by something else — unclear roles, weak governance, missing standards, or a structure quietly working against the outcome.

Courses are easy to buy and easy to count, so they get commissioned early — before anyone has defined the problem, what good looks like, or how success will be measured. The result is activity that feels like progress but rarely moves the outcome. The discipline that changes this is simple:

diagnosis before prescription.

Capability is a system, not a course. It comes from people, behaviours, governance, leadership, structure, assurance and learning working together. Training is one part of that system.

The Prelude Capability Model™

Our primary framework. Performance is traced from mission down to evidence. When any layer is missing, capability fails — and no amount of training fixes it. We use it to diagnose capability challenges and align learning, governance and workforce to organisational performance.



Read it top-down to design capability; read it bottom-up to diagnose why performance evidence isn't appearing.

The Capability Readiness Review™

The Review is the first step before investing in training, consultancy or capability development. It tests how clearly you can answer ten questions that determine whether an intervention will actually work.

- What problem are you actually trying to solve?
- What behaviours need to change?
- What impact are you trying to achieve?
- What does success look like?
- How will success be measured?
- What evidence supports your current position?
- Have you tested whether training is the real issue?
- What organisational barriers exist?
- What risks exist if nothing changes?
- What capability is required to achieve the desired outcome?

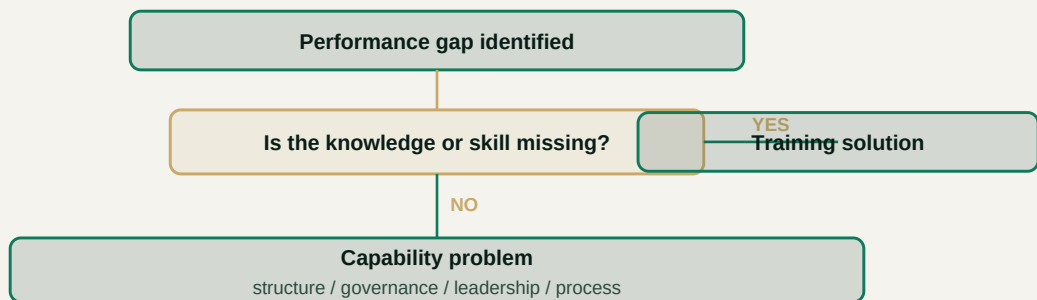
It runs at three levels: a free **self-assessment**, a facilitated **Capability Readiness Review™**, and a full **Capability Diagnostic™**.

Five common capability mistakes

- **Prescribing before diagnosing.** Commissioning a solution before the real problem is understood.
- **Treating symptoms as causes.** Reading a performance gap as a skills gap, and missing structure or governance.
- **Counting activity, not outcomes.** Measuring course completions instead of readiness or performance.
- **Running governance as box-ticking.** Using DSAT as a process to complete rather than a framework to support decisions.
- **Buying course catalogues.** Investing in learning against an undefined capability requirement.

The Training vs Capability Decision Model™

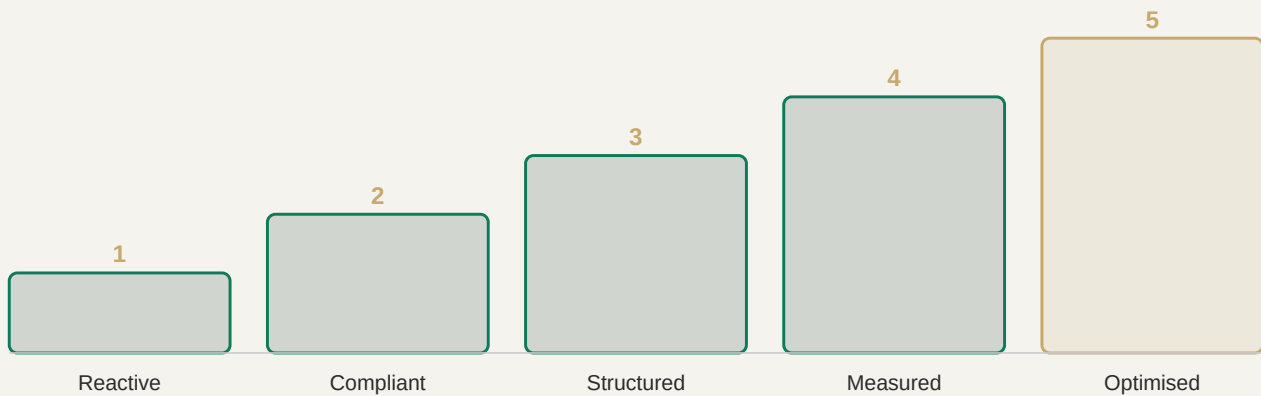
A simple test that stops organisations spending on courses when the real issue is structural. If the knowledge or skill is genuinely missing, training may help. If it isn't, the problem is capability — and lives in structure, governance, leadership or process.



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The Capability Readiness Maturity Model™

Five stages of capability maturity. Most organisations sit between Compliant and Structured, and assume the route forward is more training. It rarely is.



- **1 Reactive** — capability addressed only when something breaks.
- **2 Compliant** — driven by mandatory requirements and audit.
- **3 Structured** — defined frameworks, roles and standards in place.
- **4 Measured** — capability and readiness tracked with evidence.
- **5 Optimised** — capability continuously improved against outcomes.

Case examples

Digital Skills for Defence (DS4D) — building capability, not course catalogues

A digital problem was being framed as a training problem. By mapping mission to capability first, the real gaps were exposed: undefined capability requirements and a learning estate not aligned to outcomes. Defining the requirement and aligning the workforce delivered more progress in ten weeks than the prior twelve months.

Senior Information Officer (SIO) Course — speed and governance together

Many believe Defence change is slow because of DSAT. In reality DSAT is often treated as a process to complete rather than a framework to support decisions. A rapid, defensible TNA identified immediate improvements and future role needs while preserving DSAT defensibility and JSP 822 compliance — proving speed and governance are not a trade-off.

"In ten weeks, Jason and his team achieved more progress on the DS4D programme than had been delivered in the previous twelve months."

Senior Client · Digital Skills for Defence (DS4D)

Diagnostic questions you can use today

Before commissioning any solution, work through these with your team. If you can't answer them clearly, that — not a missing course — is where to start.

- What single problem are we actually trying to solve?
- Whose behaviour needs to change, and to what?
- What does good look like, in observable terms?
- How will we measure success, and what's our baseline?
- What evidence do we have for our current position?
- Have we genuinely tested whether this is a training issue?
- What structural, governance or leadership barriers exist?
- What is the risk — and cost — of doing nothing?
- What capability does the outcome actually require?
- Which layer of the Prelude Capability Model™ is missing?

This is a deliberate extract of the approach — enough to use, not the full facilitated method.

Working with Prelude

Jason Smith is a capability, readiness and workforce development advisor. From Royal Navy operational leadership through Defence capability specialism and consultancy at Korn Ferry, he now advises Defence, Healthcare, Housing and public sector organisations on the problems training alone never fixes.

- 15+ years across capability, leadership and readiness
 - Active SC clearance (former DV holder)
 - Defence DSAT specialist · PRINCE2 · CMI
 - Organisations supported up to 15,000 staff
 - 95% apprenticeship completion · up to 25% performance improvement
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Start with the free Capability Readiness Self-Assessment, or discuss your challenge directly.

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